

Environmental drivers of low vaccine responsiveness in a lab-to-wild rodent model

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TODO LIST

■ Estimate the interaction between diet and habitat	12
■ What do we plan to include in the supplementary methods?	16
■ @ABP, @SV: Check whether mice diet groups are mislabelled against original data.	17
■ Add details of the ISSF vaccination grant, Saudamini’s Darwin Trust funding, ABPs Chancellors Fellowship, Amy Sweeny’s Darwin Trust funding, SAB RS and BMGF. - what else?	24

ABSTRACT

Vaccination is the most effective medical intervention to prevent infectious disease and protect public health. However, most new vaccines fail late in the clinical trial pipeline, and even established vaccines often perform worse in populations that differ substantially from those in which they were initially tested. This can lead to breakthrough infections and prevent or delay herd immunity. For anthelmintic vaccines, the situation is worse still: none have progressed beyond clinical trials in humans to date. Despite decades of immunological research and vaccine development, the causes of vaccine hyporesponsiveness remain difficult to identify, quantify, and therefore, address. We and others have shown that diet could have profound impacts on anthelmintic immunity: while protein restriction disproportionately impairs type 2 immunity compared to pro-inflammatory and type 1 immunity, dietary supplementation with a nutrient-rich chow can help wild rodents reduce parasite burdens by $\sim 50\%$. Here, we therefore hypothesised that the leading causes of type-2 vaccine hyporesponsiveness are environmental, and are exacerbated when individuals are under nutritional or physiological (e.g., reproductive) stress. We used paired cohorts of laboratory-reared and wild wood mice (*Apodemus sylvaticus*) vaccinated with a single or two doses of diphtheria toxoid vaccine formulated with alum to drive type 2 responses. We show that circulating vaccine-specific IgG1 antibodies dropped on average by 50% in a wild population compared to individuals of the same species that had been reared under controlled laboratory conditions. We also found that, regardless of habitat, substantial variation in vaccine responsiveness was explained by diet, alongside weaker negative effects of being male and reproductively active. Surprisingly, helminth infection did not directly suppress vaccine-specific antibody production once habitat, diet, and sex were accounted for. While much variation within the habitat remains to be explained, our results indicate that the environment, chiefly dietary resource, plays a dramatic role in vaccine responsiveness. Further, they suggest that laboratory settings may systematically overestimate vaccine performance by failing to capture natural environmental variability. We anticipate that our study will inaugurate a robust modelling approach and biological system to disentangle and quantify the complex factors that cause vaccine responsiveness in target populations. It may also call for a need to systematically raise efficacy thresholds for initiating clinical phases of vaccine development.

INTRODUCTION

Unanticipated variability in individual responses to vaccination can lead to a lack of protection from the target disease, continued pathogen transmission, and an increased risk of the evolution of vaccine escape¹⁻⁴. Such heterogeneity in vaccine efficacy is largely driven by the individual's baseline immune state and responsiveness to novel antigen, affecting both innate and adaptive immunity, thereby potentially driving disease and transmission⁵, and are themselves the results of earlier interactions between intrinsic and environmental factors, including genetics⁶ and epigenetics⁷, sex⁸, reproductive status⁹, prior infections¹⁰⁻¹², and diet¹³⁻¹⁵. Such heterogeneities can have stark implications for human health, manifesting for example in the substantial drop in vaccine immunogenicity and efficacy in low-income or rural relative to high-income or urban populations^{16,17}. These impediments to effective vaccination are exacerbated for vaccines against helminths, for which the most at-risk individuals are found in rural and low-income populations^{18,19}. Furthermore, helminths are reported to cause poor vaccine responsiveness due to their ability to suppress their host's immunity^{20,21}, potentially compounding effects of environment and immune regulation.

Unsurprisingly, only a small minority of vaccines successfully transition from the preclinical stages of development through phase III trials and reach mass market²², and there are still no antihelminthic vaccines for human helminthiases. Furthermore, even the most successful vaccines can suffer substantial loss of efficacy, notably for people of different ancestry²³ or different habitats¹⁷ than the populations in which they are initially deployed. For example, individuals of Tanzanian ancestry were reported to have higher inflammatory and type 1 immune markers²⁴ and responses to measles vaccination²⁵ than those of European ancestry, while in rural populations the expression of BCG- and tetanus-specific cytokine recall and antibody responses was found to be markedly lower than in urban populations, while humoral responses to tetanus vaccination were higher^{26,27}.

Similar patterns have been observed across multiple vaccines¹⁷. Taken together, these reports indicate that vaccine efficacy depends on both the vaccine and the recipients' characteristics, and that there are substantial gaps in our ability to predict and address lack or loss of vaccine efficacy across individuals and populations. Indeed, given the complex processes that regulate protective immune responses, it is unclear how all these factors interact with each-other and with the environment, and which among them could be intervened upon to maximise vaccination efficacy.

To increase the generalisability of experimental models of immunology and vaccinology, recent efforts have been made to integrate natural variability into immunological research^{28–32}. These include exposing mice to richer, “dirtier” environments, littermates, and microbiota, which stimulates mice to develop more mature, and thus more representative, immune systems and responses to infection. However, there is still uncertainty about how this heterogeneity affects the innate and adaptive arms of the immune system³³, and what consequences this might have for vaccine responsiveness. More specifically, it is unclear how environmental factors and past stressors influence organisms' responses to immunisation. This complexity obscures the causal relationships between environmental and immunological processes, making the design and interpretation of *in vivo* vaccination experiments difficult and their impact on their intended target populations less tractable.

To disentangle the relative contributions of environmental variables to vaccine responsiveness, we conducted randomised controlled vaccination and dietary supplementation in a coupled laboratory-wild rodent study system, the wood mouse *Apodemus sylvaticus*. Using the same assays and interventions in the same genetically outbred species across habitats allowed us to better isolate the effect of the wild habitat by minimising confounding effects of species as well as reagent availability and specificity. Although supplementation of wild populations prevents accurate measure of individual dietary intake and feeding preference (wild mice are free to forage), we have previously shown in the same wild populations that

diet supplementation drives a sustained reduction in helminth (*Heligmosomoides polygyrus*) burdens and transmission, while also improving the efficacy of anthelmintic treatment³⁴. We therefore predicted that type 2 anthelmintic vaccine responses in wild mice would be lower than in lab wood mice and higher in diet-supplemented than normal-diet animals. To test these predictions we constructed a structural causal model (SCM)³⁵ to partition the causal effects of habitat, diet, sex, and parasite infection on vaccine-specific IgG1 responsiveness and to identify the paths through which their effects are mediated. This causal framework, which uses graphical models to inform adjustment strategies^{36,37}, can eliminate or reduce multiple sources of confounding, such as common causes (misattribution of causal effects), sampling biases (non-representative test population), and transportability biases (lack of generalisability). We used Bayesian models to estimate the average direct and indirect causes of loss of vaccine efficacy when translating a vaccine from the laboratory to the wild, and to accurately model how uncertainty and biological variability propagate through the causal structure.

RESULTS

Vaccination induced stronger but variable antibody responses in the laboratory than in the wild

Wild and laboratory *A. sylvaticus* wood mice were given a high- or low-quality diet and then immunised with a diphtheria-alum vaccine (DTV) once or twice. DTV-specific IgG1 serum concentrations were then measured by ELISA seven to 35 days post immunisation (see details in Materials, Methods, and Models; Figure 1).

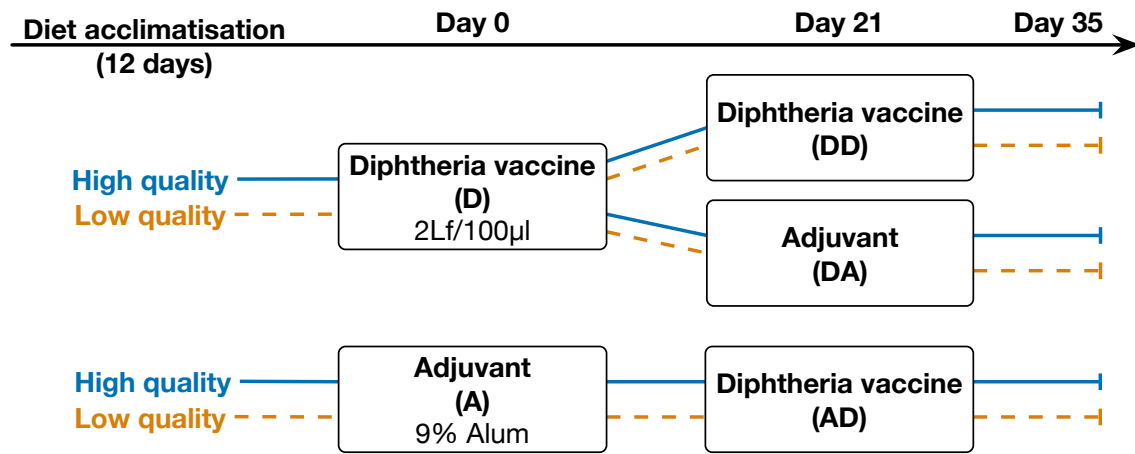


Fig. 1: Allocation of diet and vaccines. Wood mice from a laboratory colony, and from the wild were provided enriched (TransBreed) or standard (lab: normal chow; wild: no supplementation) diets. After at least 12 days, mice were allocated at random to immunisation with a 2Lf/100µl Diphtheria Toxoid + 9% alum vaccine (D) or with adjuvant alone (A). Twenty-one days after their first immunisation, mice that had been immunised with D were then given a second shot of the vaccine (DD) or adjuvant alone (DA), while mice that had received an initial adjuvant vaccine (A) were all given D for their second shot (AD).

Wild mice generated $46.9\% \pm 0.1\%$ lower DTV-specific IgG1 antibody responses than their lab-based conspecifics, regardless of the vaccine regimen or diet (Figure 2A, 2B ‘Hab’). While immunisation was most effective with two doses in both habitats, lab mice reached peak antibody levels with only a single dose (Figure 2A, ‘DA’ vs ‘DD’; Lab boosted vs. Lab non-boosted $OD = 0.2 \pm 0.1$ whereas Wild boosted vs. Wild non-boosted $OD = 1.02 \pm 0.23$). However, in the wild, only when given two doses did the mice show responsiveness similar to the level observed in laboratory mice (Figure 2A, ‘DD’; difference between Wild non-boosted vs. Lab non-boosted $OD = 0.75 \pm 0.11$ while difference between Wild boosted vs. Lab boosted $OD = 0.61 \pm 0.18$; LRT of Habitat $\times$ vaccine regimen: $\Delta dof = 4, \chi^2 = 30.6, p < 0.001$). Only mice that were administered the DT antigen generated DTV-specific IgG1, indicating that there was no pre-existing immunity to this antigen in our study populations (Figure 2A, group ‘A’).

To further quantify how habitat (lab vs. wild), diet (supplemented vs. control), and the immunisation protocol were associated with variation in vaccine responsiveness, we constructed a multilevel Bayesian model of those factors with varying intercepts for each

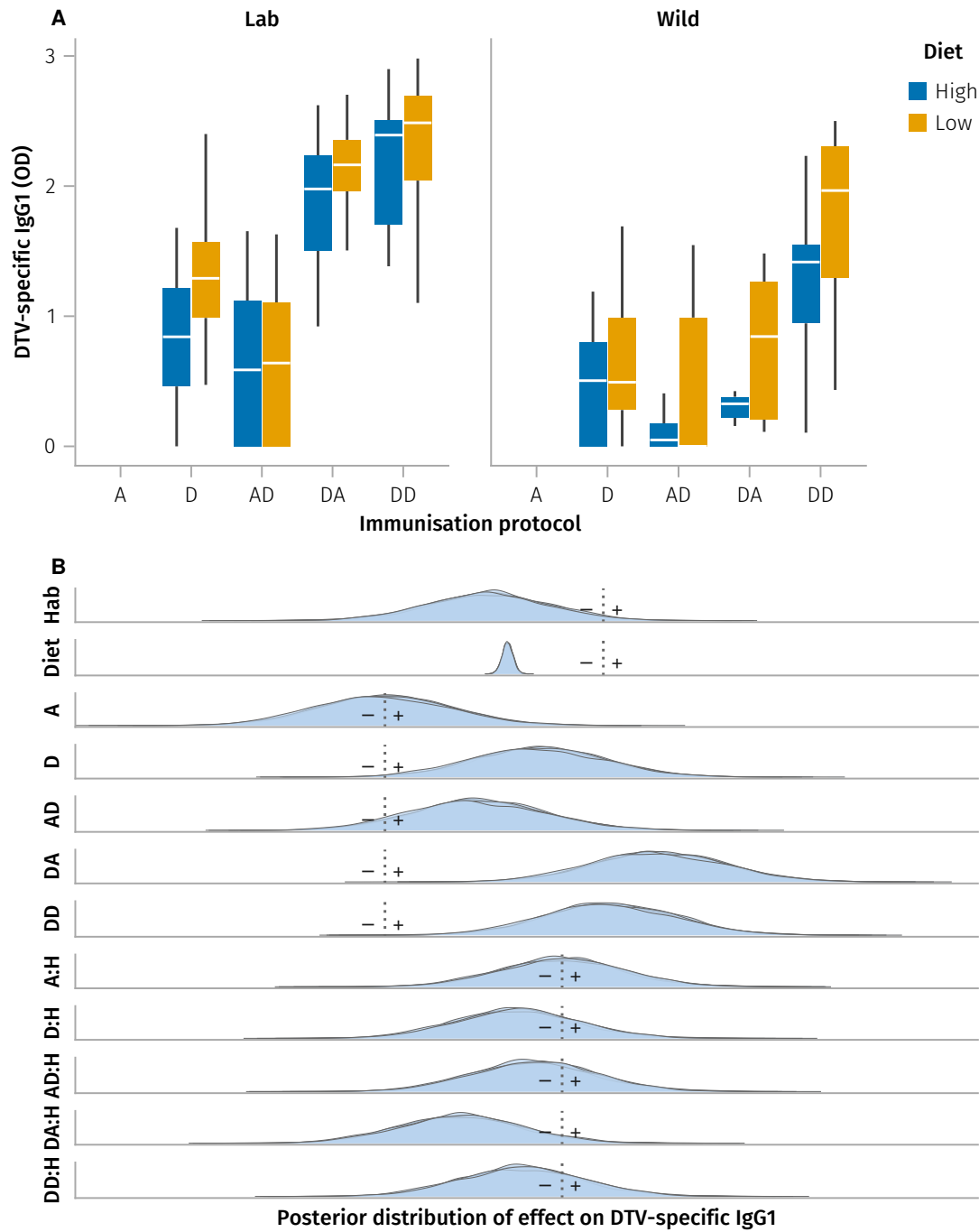


Fig. 2: Vaccine-induced DTV-specific IgG1. **A**, diphtheria toxoid vaccine (DTV)-specific IgG1 optical density in mice from laboratory- and wild-habitats provided high and low quality dietary supplements. Mice were immunised either once, with adjuvant as control (A) or DTV (D), or twice, using adjuvant alone followed by DTV (AD), DTV and subsequently adjuvant alone (DA), or two separate doses of DTV (DD). Only mice immunised at least 7 days prior to serum ELISA sampling are shown. **B**, posterior conditional distributions of the coefficients for diet, habitat, and vaccine formulation (A, D, AD, DA, DD), and effect of the same vaccines. Each density curve represents the distribution of 3,000 samples from one of four MCMC chains; dotted line represents the value for which the reference (global intercept for Diet and Habitat; Adjuvant alone for the vaccines) is null (see parameter estimates in Table 1).

immunisation protocol (Figure 2B, Table 1). This model indicated that the effects of each vaccine formulation on DTV-specific IgG1 OD were substantially more variable than those of habitat and diet. Further, it shows that vaccine responsiveness for all regimens but especially DA, i.e. a single early immunisation, was substantially degraded in the wild, indicating a faster loss of vaccine-induced immunity in the wild than in the lab (Figure 2B, Table 1).

However, this model does not explain how habitat and diet are driving this loss of efficacy. Therefore, it does not indicate which mechanisms might be targeted to prevent this loss of responsiveness. Further, it does not account for potential confounding and mediating effects of sex, reproductive status, body mass, body fat, or parasite burdens, which we hypothesise to contribute to variation in vaccine responsiveness. To address these limitations, we then constructed a structural causal model (SCM) of the processes generating variation in vaccine responsiveness $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ in this study system.

Construction of a structural causal model of vaccine responsiveness

To understand more specifically the relative contributions of diet and habitat to vaccine responsiveness, and how that effect might be mediated by parasite infection, reproductive status, and body condition, we built a causal model of vaccine efficacy in the wood mouse system, first by constructing a graphical model of our hypotheses, then using our data to validate and refine its structure (see casual flow diagram, Fig. S1).

The resulting causal directed acyclic graph (DAG) $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ and corresponding SCM $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ then allowed us to estimate vaccine responsiveness E as a function of vaccination V , habitat H and diet supplementation D , and more importantly, to identify which variables could act as confounders or mediators that might modulate vaccine responsiveness. In summary, the DAG $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ (Figure 3A) represents the hypothesised structure of the biological processes that cause the variation in vaccine responsiveness observed in this system, and the corresponding SCM $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Figure 3B) that links (via the edges in $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$) our variables

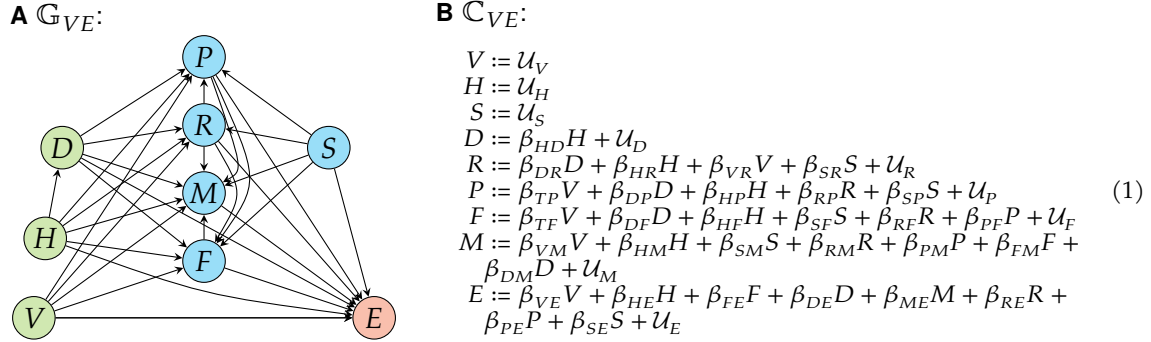


Fig. 3: Causal Model of vaccine responsiveness. **A**, Directed acyclic graph $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ representing hypothesised causal effects driving variation in efficacy E of vaccine V in laboratory or wild mice H , under supplemented or control diet D (green nodes depict experimental treatments). Covariates, mediators, and potential confounders (blue nodes) were time since vaccination T , parasite infection (presence or burden) P , reproductive status R , body mass M , fat scores F , and sex S . Directed edges depict causal effects hypothesised to operate between nodes. **B**, Structural causal model $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ derived from $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ with coefficients β_{ij} representing the effect of cause i on effect j . $\mathcal{U}_j$ represents the unmeasured variation of the response variable, not represented in $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ (panel A) for clarity.

of interest (nodes in $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$) to vaccine efficacy E under the different habitat and dietary treatments.

- Vaccination V was allocated at random, and therefore has no parent node. It was hypothesised to potentially affect parasite infection P , reproductive status R , body mass M and fat stores F through non-specific effects in addition to its main intended effect on vaccine responsiveness E .
- Whether a mouse was born in the lab or in the wild habitat H was considered random and therefore took no parent node, but was hypothesised to potentially affect all other variables except V and sex S .
- Diet D was allocated at random in the laboratory colony, but because wild mice could also forage freely, we considered that being born in the wild could have a causal effect on diet, specifically on the effect of supplementation relative to the control laboratory or the wild diet. We therefore considered a causal effect of H on D . Diet was hypothesised to affect reproductive status R , body mass M , body fat F and parasite burdens P as well as E , with fat scores F hypothesised to be a cause of variation in body mass M .

- Sex S being genetically determined and therefore subject to Mendelian randomisation³⁸, and all treatments being randomised with respect to sex, S had no parent node, and was considered causally prior to reproductive status R , body mass M , body fat F and parasite burdens P .
- Reproductive status R being driven by sex, it was hypothesised to affect body mass M and parasite burden P .
- Vaccine responsiveness E was hypothesised to be affected by all other variables.
- Each node also had its own error term to capture all unobserved sources of variation, assumed to be independent and identically distributed (Figure 3B).

Validation of the causal model

We then tested the validity of the causal hypotheses described above, using $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ to construct each model. For example, $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ (Figure 3A) indicates that parasite infection should be independent of vaccination if we adjust for diet, reproductive status, sex, and habitat ($P \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid D, R, S, H$); therefore, we fitted a binomial generalised linear mixed model $P \sim \alpha + \beta_V V + \beta_D D + \beta_R R + \beta_S S + \beta_H H + (1|ID)$, and confirmed that the posterior distribution of β_D was not significantly different from zero. This process was repeated for all implied independencies derived from the causal graph $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ (see Model validation methods), and $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ was updated until all causal paths were both supported by the observed data and consistent with biological expectations.

Causal analysis indicates preponderant effects of diet and habitat on vaccine responsiveness

Using the resulting, validated, DAG, we parametrised $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Model 1) using Bayesian linear models to estimate the total and direct causal effects operating within $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ (Fig. 4). Vaccination had an average causal effect of 1.50 ± 0.13 ($\log_{10} + 1$)-transformed OD units ($\log OD$) relative to unvaccinated animals and no indirect effects mediated by body fat

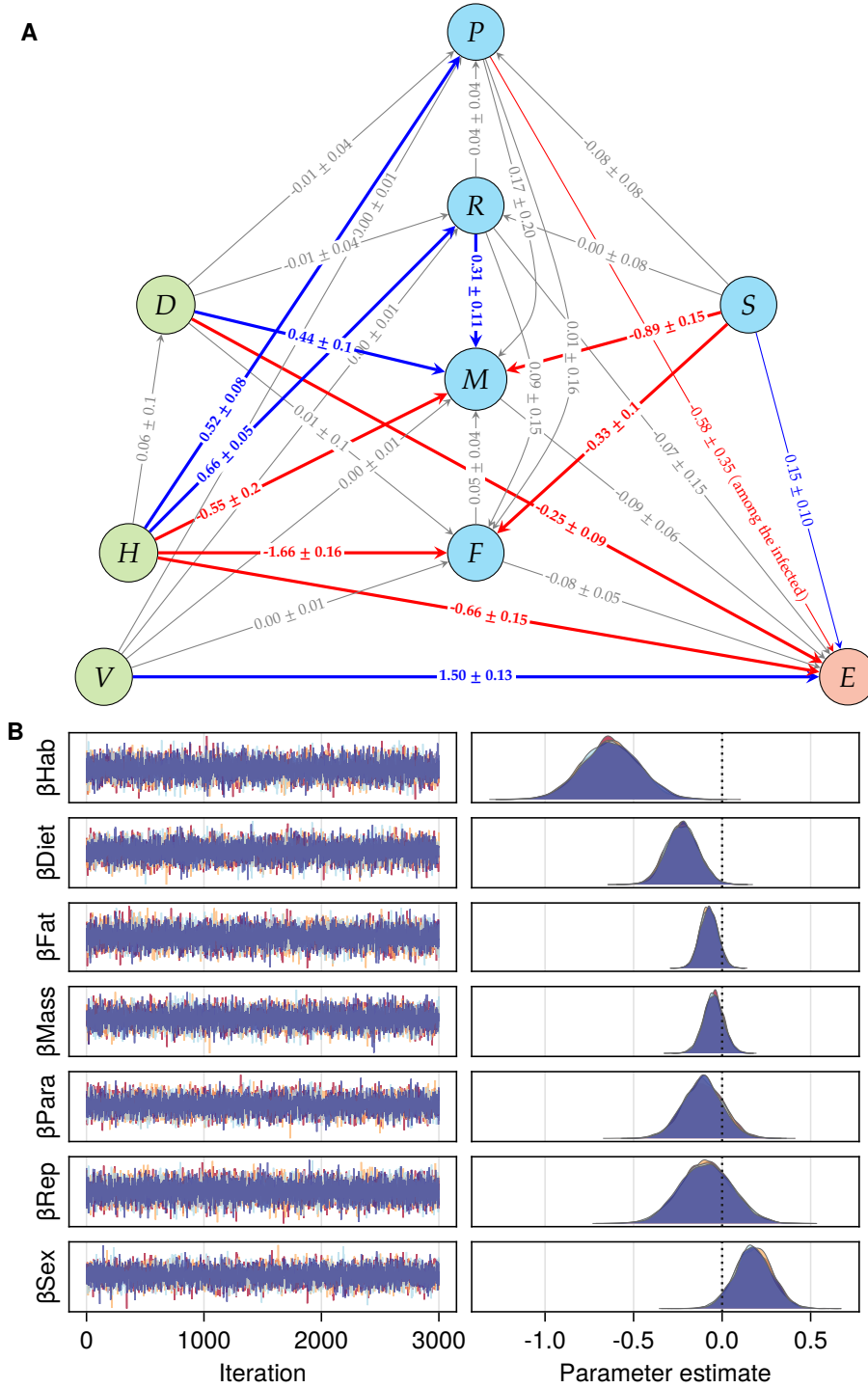


Fig. 4: Fully resolved Causal Model of vaccine efficacy. **A**, Directed acyclic graph representing point estimates of positive (blue) and negative (red) direct causal effects $\pm$ std driving vaccine responsiveness E . **B**, MCMC sampling of posterior distributions of the coefficients estimating the direct effect of the wild habitat H on vaccine responsiveness E , with the adjustment set including, Diet D , Fat scores F , body mass M , parasite burden P , active reproductive status R , and female sex S ; vaccine formulation V and individual treated as random effects: $E := \beta_{Hab}H + \beta_{Diet}D + \beta_{Fat}F + \beta_{Mass}M + \beta_{Para}P + \beta_{Rep}R + \beta_{Sex}S + \mathcal{N}(0, Exp(\sigma_E))$ (see Model parameterisation methods). Note that each edge in panel A shows the direct causal effect of parent node on its child node, which is conditional on the specific adjustment set for that model; thus, only the coefficient β_{Diet} for the edge between D and E is a causal estimate in panel B, while the others are only associative.

F, body mass *M*, reproductive status *R* or parasite burden *P* (Fig. 4B). However, vaccine responsiveness was strongly influenced by both wild habitat and dietary supplementation.

Habitat had wide ranging effects on wood mice and their response to vaccination

Living in the wild had a total negative effect on vaccine-specific IgG1 of $-0.46 \pm 0.24 \log OD$, partitioned between body mass *M* with a direct negative impact of $-0.66 \pm 0.15 \log OD$ (corresponding to wild wood mice being on average 1.3 ± 0.2 g lighter than their laboratory counterparts), and body fat *F* (reduction by 2.3 fat score points on the 6-point scale).

Wood mice in the wild but not in the lab could freely reproduce and were naturally exposed to *H. polygyrus*, reflected in direct causal effects of 0.66 ± 0.05 and 0.52 ± 0.08 of *H* on *R* and *P*, respectively. Consistent with expectations under random diet allocation, there was no effect of habitat *H* on diet *D*.

Diet supplementation reduced vaccine responsiveness

The total causal effect of diet supplementation on vaccine responsiveness was estimated to be $-0.25 \pm 0.09 \log OD$, adjusted for habitat. However, the direct effect of diet supplementation on vaccine responsiveness was estimated to be $-0.23 \pm 0.09 \log OD$, when adjusting for body mass, fat stores, habitat, sex, reproductive status, parasite burden, and vaccine formulation. This indicates that the effect of diet supplementation on vaccine responsiveness was mostly direct (or mediated by unobserved variables along the path $D \rightarrow E$, e.g. immune pathways affecting DTV-specific IgG1 production or the microbiome), but was not mediated by its effects on body mass, fat stores, reproductive status, or parasite burden. Dietary supplementation increased body mass on average by 2.53 ± 0.3 g, though did not affect body fat scores.

Estimate the interaction between diet and habitat

Sex had both direct and indirect effects on vaccine responsiveness

The total causal effect of sex on DTV-specific antibody production *E* indicated greater vaccine responsiveness in females ($0.26 \pm 0.15 \log OD$). However, only a little more than

half of the effect of sex ($0.15 \pm 0.10 \log OD$) was direct, with body mass ($0.08 \pm 0.01 \log OD$) and body fat ($0.03 \pm 0.005 \log OD$) mediating the rest (Fig. 4).

Negative effect of parasite burdens on vaccine responsiveness among the infected

When considering the entire population, including uninfected mice, *H. polygyrus* burden had no clear effect on DT vaccine responsiveness ($-0.13 \pm 0.11 \log OD$). However, because parasite infections are overdispersed and zero-inflated, we also estimated the causal effects of infection burden on DT vaccine responsiveness only among infected wild wood mice. Parasite burden among the infected had a negative direct causal effect on vaccine responsiveness ($-0.58 \pm 0.35 \log OD$), when adjusting for diet, sex, reproductive status, and vaccination.

DISCUSSION

We built a structural causal model of vaccine responsiveness in wood mice to estimate the effects of a natural wild habitat and of dietary supplementation were partitioned among parasitological and physiological traits. The three main observations were the substantial variation in vaccine efficacy between individuals, and that both the wild habitat and dietary supplementation resulted in lower vaccine responsiveness. This emphasises the importance of environmental factors for responses to immunisation at both individual and population levels, consistent with reports across multiple habitats and species including humans^{26,39–41}.

Indeed, there was a marked hyporesponsiveness in wild wood mouse populations relative to their laboratory counterparts, despite being immunised with the same Diphtheria Toxoid vaccine formulations. The detrimental effects of the natural habitat on vaccine responsiveness were only partially rescued by a booster dose of the vaccine. This reduction is consistent with widespread reports of vaccine failure during clinical trials, notably in phase III where vaccines are tested for efficacy in naturally exposed individuals²², or in

already-established vaccines in rural populations^{17,42}. Part of the loss of vaccine responsiveness in the wild habitat was mediated by parasite infection, consistent with reports in humans and animals showing that parasitic helminths can negatively impact vaccination^{10,43–46}. These reports are not unanimous, however, with many reporting no⁴⁷ or even a positive association between vaccine responsiveness and parasitic infection^{11,12}. These discrepancies might be caused by the vaccine formulations and by the immune measurements chosen. However, our present study suggests that conflicting inferences might be resolved by how parasite infection is estimated: we only detected a negative effect of parasite burden among the infected animals, and no effect when uninfected individuals were included in the analysis. Animal studies have highlighted the immunoregulatory effects of gastrointestinal parasites, in particular of *H. bakeri*^{21,48}. Here, the immune system of wood mice naturally infected by *H. polygyrus*, which is distinct from the laboratory model⁴⁹, might similarly be actively suppressed by the parasite. Alternatively, animals inherently more susceptible to helminth infection might have a generally lower propensity to generate strong antibody responses, which we detect “collaterally” as poor anti-vaccine responsiveness. Resolving these alternatives would require testing the prediction of both vaccine responsiveness and helminth burden from immune profiling prior to both infection and vaccination (see for example^{50,51}).

While habitat significantly affected body mass, body fat, and reproductive status, those effects did not propagate to vaccine efficacy, indicating a preponderance of as yet unmeasured factors summarised by the natural direct effect of habitat on vaccine responsiveness in the wild. These might include coinfections other than *H. bakeri* or differences in microbiota independent of dietary supplementation (because we adjusted for that), among other physiological and environmental factors that might impact relevant immune pathways.

The second major cause of vaccine hyporesponsiveness was dietary supplementation. This was surprising, as based on earlier work, we had predicted that diet supplementation

would increase vaccine responsiveness. Indeed, we have previously shown that the same diet, in the same populations of the same species reduced parasite burdens³⁴. However, in this study, diet had no effect of parasite burdens, but caused a weaker response to the vaccines. We hypothesise that a possible explanation for these observations is that the immune system adopts different strategies depending on the availability and composition of nutritional resources. This is consistent with our and other's studies reporting a pro-inflammatory effect of protein scarcity^{52,53}.

Effect of nutrition was unexpected. See¹⁵. WTF is going on with diet effect on worm burdens?

The 'wild habitat' captures many variables that would still need to be identified — these might include weather, predation, competition, and other stressors that are absent from laboratory conditions.

The direct edge for V to E dissimulates a large number of pathways that are likely to mediate the environmental effects on vaccine responsiveness. These could include the effects of diet on the gut microbiome, on hormonal regulation, and on more canonical immune pathways.

We have focused on the response to immunisation; the next step will be to evaluation how variability in responsiveness affects protection against pathogens, i.e., vaccine efficacy.

Females overall responded better to vaccination than males, partly as a direct effect of sex (i.e. through unmeasured mediation) and partly mediated by body mass and fat content.

Limitations & Perspectives.

- Only one antibody isotype;
- Only IgG1 measured. would be good to also measure IgG2a and IgM.

- Complete diet supplementation, not possible to analyse nutrients, nor to measure how much of the feed was taken by each individual.
- A consequence of increased variability in natural populations is the need for increased sample sizes during clinical trials⁵⁴.

We made the following simplifying assumptions:

- Parametric assumptions and linearity of the causal effects. Future work will need to generalise the functional form of the causal effects to allow for non-linear effects of the variables on vaccine responsiveness.
- no unmeasured confounders. Future work will need to relax these assumptions to allow for more complex causal structures and to account for unmeasured confounders and mediation.
- Random vaccine and diet treatments: We should allow vaccine and diet uptake (propensity scores) to vary among the treated, as, especially in the wild population, these are not strictly enforced.

MATERIALS, METHODS, AND MODELS

All animal work was conducted in accordance to UK Home Office in compliance with the Animals (Scientific Procedures) Act, 1986. Both laboratory and field experiments were approved by the University of Edinburgh Ethical Review Committee and carried out under the UK Home Office Project Licence 70/8543. The dosage of diphtheria vaccine was tested in laboratory-bred wood mice before the experiments for safety and efficacy. Animal sacrifice was performed using appropriate Schedule 1 Methods. Fieldwork was carried out with permission of the Forestry Commission Scotland under the permit SUR09.

See Supp methods

What do we plan to include in the supplementary methods?

Laboratory wood mouse experiment

The laboratory experiment was carried out on a colony of wild-derived but now captive outbred wood mouse colony that has been bred and maintained at the University of Edinburgh³⁴ (See SI for more details). The experiment was carried out in two replicate blocks, with 36 animals in each block (18 males, 18 females). At 12 days before the start of the experiment (d-12), all mice were shifted to new diet regimes and given time to acclimatise; half of the animals in each block (9 males and 9 females) were given TransBreedTM, a high quality whole-diet mouse food. We have previously shown that wood mice supplemented with TransBreedTM were more resistant to the gastrointestinal nematode *Heligmosomoides polygyrus*, cleared worms more effectively after anthelmintic treatment and produced stronger general (total IgA) and parasite-specific (IgG) immune responses in both wild and laboratory conditions³⁴. The other half of the mice in this experiment were fed RM1 (Rat and Mouse Maintenance), a lower quality diet, but commonly used maintenance mouse food that supports maintenance. Both TransBreedTM and RM1 are standard laboratory diets, with TransBreedTM containing higher amounts of starch, protein, fat, and micronutrients compared to RM1 (see SI for detailed nutritional compositions). Within each diet regime, both male and female animals were randomly assigned to three experimental groups (Fig. 1). Animals belonging to Groups 1 & 2 (n = 24) were subcutaneously injected with 100µl of diphtheria vaccine (2 Lf per 100µl of adjuvant (9% Potassium Aluminium Sulphate) on d0. The vaccine was prepared in our laboratory one day before administration, using vaccine-grade diphtheria inactivated toxoid protein (Alpha Diagnostic International) adsorbed to the adjuvant (9% Alum). Animals assigned to Group 3 (n = 12) were injected with a control, referred to as 'adjuvant'; 100µl of adjuvant (9% potassium aluminium sulphate) suspended in 1X PBS on d0. Small volume blood samples were taken via tail snip 14 and 17 days after the first injections (d14 and d17) to measure the primary antibody response. Twenty-one days (d21) after the first injections,

@ABP, @SV:
Check whether
mice diet groups
are mislabelled
against original
data.

the animals of Group 1 ($n = 12$) were injected again with 100 μ l of the diphtheria vaccine (referred to as the 'booster'), while those assigned to Group 2 ($n = 12$) were injected with the control dose as described above (referred to as 'adjuvant'). Animals assigned to Group 3 ($n = 12$) that had previously been injected with the control dose now received an injection of 100 μ l diphtheria vaccine. Another blood sample (20- 50 μ l) was taken a day later (d22) by cheek venipuncture. All animals were sacrificed 14 days after the second injection (d35) and a blood sample for measuring the secondary antibody response was taken. The same procedures and timeline were carried out for the second experimental block of animals ($n = 36$). Mice were co-housed throughout the experiment, in same-sex groups of three, with equal representation of the three experimental groups in each cage.

Wild wood mice experiment

We conducted a 10-week field experiment in a natural population of wood mice with a design similar to that of the laboratory experiment. The experiment took place in a woodland in Falkirk, Scotland, UK (Callendar Wood, 55.990470, -3.766636), where we established four trapping grids (60m $\times$ 40m per grid) with 10 m spacing between each of the 35 trapping stations. At each station, we set a pair of Sherman live traps (H.B. Sherman 2X2.5X6.5-inch folding trap, Tallahassee, FL, USA). We randomly selected two of the four grids to be 'supplemented'; 12 days before we began live-trapping, we started supplementing these grids with extra resources. Specifically, we scattered 6 kg TransBreedTM (high quality, whole- diet mouse food) pellets evenly around the grid, and this supplementation continued throughout the experiment, twice per week. The two 'control' grids did not receive any supplementation. Wood mice in all four grids had access to their normal diet and food items, so these additional resources on the supplemented grids served as an additional high nutritional food resource.

From July-September 2018, wood mice were trapped 2–3 nights per week using live traps baited with grains, carrots, and bedding. Additionally, traps on the supplemented

grids were also baited with 1-2 TransBreed™ pellets. For identification, all newly captured mice weighing >13g were subcutaneously tagged with a unique 9-digit microchip passive induced transponder (PIT tag; FriendChip AVID2028, Norco, CA, USA). On first capture, mice were assigned to one of the three vaccine treatment groups described above in the laboratory experiment; mice assigned to these groups received the same primary and booster doses of the diphtheria vaccine or control injections as described below (see Figure 1). Throughout the experiment, weekly small volume blood samples were taken via tail snip from each tagged animal to measure their antibody response to the diphtheria immunisation. Animals recaptured 14 or more days after their second injection were sacrificed and a terminal bleed was collected to measure their antibody response and adult *Heligmosomoides polygyrus* worm burdens. *H. polygyrus* is a natural gastrointestinal nematode found at high prevalence (20-100 %) in wild populations of *A. sylvaticus*^{34,55–57}, as well as being a well-studied model system of human gastrointestinal nematodes where it has been found to be highly immunomodulatory^{48,58}.

Additionally, at all captures, we took the following demographic metrics for each individual: sex, body condition, reproductive condition, weight (g), and length (mm). Sex and reproductive condition of each mouse was assigned by examining the genitals, with males having larger urogenital gap compared to females. Males were classified as reproductively active if their testes had visibly descended to scrotal sacs, and females were classified as reproductively active if they had a perforated vagina or were visibly pregnant or lactating. Body condition was measured by assigning dorsal and pelvic fat scores on a qualitative scale from 1-5, where 1 represented a mouse with very low condition, while a 5 represented a mouse with ample fat reserves. This was achieved by palpating the back and pubic bones⁵⁹.

Vaccine responsiveness

Vaccine responsiveness was measured as the concentration of anti-diphtheria IgG1 antibodies; this is the gold standard method used in vaccinology to measure the antibody-specific response to immunisation and is used specifically for the diphtheria toxoid vaccine used here⁶⁰. To measure diphtheria vaccine responsiveness, we collected blood samples from both the laboratory and the wild mice and these were centrifuged (@24,000 rpm for 10 min) within 4–6 hours of collection. The sera were separated from the pellets and stored at -80 °C until further analysis. We used ELISAs adapted for diphtheria-specific antibodies from Clerc et al. (2019a), to quantify anti-diphtheria IgG1 antibodies in the sera samples. 96-well plates (NuncTM MicroWellTM) were coated overnight at 4 °C with diphtheria toxin (2 µg/mL) diluted in carbonate buffer (50 µl per well). After washing the plates with TBS (10 X) and Tween80 thrice, 100 µl of TBS(1X)-4percent BSA was added per well and incubated at 37 °C for 2 hours to block non-specific binding sites. Plates were then tapped dry and 50 µl of serum samples serially diluted (starting dilution 1:100) in TBS (1X)-4percent BSA buffer were added per well and left at 4 °C for binding overnight. The next day, 50 µl HRP-conjugated anti-mouse IgG1 detection antibody (Southern BioTech) per well was added after washing the plates 4 times with TBS (10X) and Tween80 and tapping them dry. After incubation at 37 °C for 1 hour, the plates were washed again, first 4 times with TBS (10X) and Tween80 and then twice with dH2O. Then, 50 µl of TMB substrate solution were added per well and the enzymatic reaction was left to develop in the dark for 7 min. The reaction was stopped after 7 min using 50 µl sulphuric acid (0.18 M) per well. Absorbance at 450 nm was recorded using an ELISA plate reader (Multiscan, Ascent Labsystems) immediately thereafter. For each sample, blank-centred optical densities (OD) of three consecutive wells (of dilutions 1:3200, 1:6400, 1:12800) were averaged to obtain diphtheria-specific IgG antibody concentration.

Data processing and analyses

ELISA optical densities of DT-specific antibodies (E) were $1 + \log_{10}$ -transformed and, body weight (M), fat scores (F) and days post-vaccination ($T \geq 1$), were Z score-transformed to help the selection of sensible priors and to improve computational stability. All models were adjusted for time T between vaccination and blood collection to account for natural kinetics of the antibody response. Fat scores ranged from 2 to 5 and were derived from the sum of two five-point scales for pelvic and dorsal fat, where 1 is 'bony' to palpation and 5 is 'fat', and were treated as continuous for the analysis. All other variables were treated as binary.

All data processing was performed in Julia v1.10⁶¹ using packages CSV.jl⁶² and DataFrames.jl⁶³.

Generalised linear mixed models of the effects of experimental interventions on habitat, diet, and vaccine formulation

Generalised linear mixed models (GLMM) were used to estimate the effects of habitat, diet, and vaccine formulation on vaccine-specific antibody concentrations measured as optical density read-outs. Mouse ID was modelled as a random effect to account for multiple testing. The interactions between vaccine regimen and habitat, and between diet and habitat, were included in the full model to test whether mice in the wild would respond differently to vaccine timing and boosting or to diet supplementation than laboratory mice. Likelihood ratio tests (LRT) were used to test the contribution of the interaction terms to the model. We used Julia v1.9⁶¹ package MixedModels.jl v4.13⁶⁴ was used for GLMMs and LRTs.

We used Bayesian multilevel models to minimise the effects of imbalance on our analyses and to quantify the uncertainty of those estimates. The intercept and slope priors were chosen to conform to the observed data, with equal means and $2.5 \times$ the observed variance (see Supplementary Data: Multilevel Models). Typically, intercepts were given

Gaussian priors of mean $\mu = \text{mean}(y)$ and $2.5 \times \sigma$ those of the observed response variable y while population-level coefficients were given multivariate normal (Gaussian) priors of mean $\mu = 0$ and variance $\sigma = 2$. Population-level residuals were assumed to follow an exponential distribution with scale $\theta = 1/\text{std}(y)$. Parameters for group level intercepts and coefficients were given Gaussian priors and their variances were given positive-truncated Cauchy priors with location $x_0 = 0$ and scale $\gamma = 2$. Posterior estimates were sampled using the Hamiltonian Monte Carlo algorithm No U-Turn Sampler⁶⁵, typically across 4 threads simultaneously with $> 3,000$ draws. Turing.jl⁶⁶ was used for Bayesian modelling; Makie.jl v0.17⁶⁷ was used for plotting.

Structural Causal Models

The structural causal model (SCM) framework^{35,68} proposes explicit qualitative solutions to biases inherent in datasets and can guide the statistical estimation of the mechanisms by which data are generated in complex systems^{69,70}. Further, Bayesian statistical methods for estimating the causal effects indicated by the SCM allow flexibility of unbalanced small data and missing values⁷¹, and provide explicit estimation of uncertainty given assumptions made by the model⁷². Specifically, here we have made three important assumptions: vaccine, diet, and habitat treatments are random; there are no (statistically relevant) unmeasured confounders; and all relationships between variables are linear.

Model construction

Each of the variables X described above was included in the structural causal model $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ with the following assignments of the form $X_j := f(X_{k \neq j}) + \mathcal{U}_j$ where the unmeasured noise variable $\mathcal{U}_j \sim \text{Normal}(0, 4)$, was assumed to be independent and identically distributed, and $f()$ was assumed to be linear (Supplementary Data: SCM construction):

A directed acyclic graph (DAG) expressing $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Model 1) was used to build unfounded models to estimate causal effects between each variable (Figure 3).

Model construction was performed in Julia v1.10⁶¹ using package Dagitty.jl and Turing.jl⁶⁶, and $\mathbb{G}_{VE}$ corresponding to $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ was drawn in TikZ⁷³.

Model validation

To validate $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Model 1), we tested the independencies it implies following chain, fork, and collider rules^{35,74}. Specifically, we used the observed values for each of the nodes of the causal graph (Figure 3) to test the truth of the following 13 implied independences: $(D \perp\!\!\!\perp S)$, $(D \perp\!\!\!\perp T \mid H)$, $(D \perp\!\!\!\perp V)$, $(F \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid T, H)$, $(H \perp\!\!\!\perp S)$, $(H \perp\!\!\!\perp V)$, $(M \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid T, H)$, $(P \perp\!\!\!\perp T \mid D, R, S, H)$, $(P \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid T, H)$, $(P \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid D, R, S, H)$, $(R \perp\!\!\!\perp V \mid T, H)$, $(S \perp\!\!\!\perp T)$, and $(S \perp\!\!\!\perp V)$. For each of these tests, we constructed a generalised linear mixed model with the appropriate link function, with mouse ID and immunisation protocol as random effects, and considered the statement true if $P_X > 0.1$, where $X \subseteq \mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Supplementary Data: SCM construction). We used MixedModels.jl v4.13⁶⁴ to test the conditional independencies implied by $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$.

Model parameterisation

Next, we encoded $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ as a Bayesian network in Turing.jl⁶⁶ to represent each variable as a probability distribution to be updated by the observed values. This allowed us to capture conditional expected values for each variable and their uncertainty. Models were constructed as described in Generalised linear mixed models of the effects of experimental interventions on habitat, diet, and vaccine formulation, code provided in Supplementary Data: SCM specification. Posterior estimates were validated with MixedModels.jl⁶⁴.

Missing data. Twenty-two mice had no fat scores, resulting in 67 missing values in the full repeated sampling dataset. To avoid having to remove those mice from the analysis, we used Bayesian imputation to estimate plausible probability distributions of each of the missing values in light of its parents (PA) in $\mathbb{C}_{VE}$ (Model 1), where $F := f(PA_F) = f(T, H, D, P, S)$ (Figure 3).

$\hat{F}$ denotes the variable F that contains imputed values; E_i denotes the expected distribution of E given $\hat{F}$.

Model updating and sampling. All Bayesian modelling was performed in Julia v1.9⁶¹ using package Turing.jl v0.25⁶⁶.

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COMPETING INTERESTS

The authors declare that there are no competing interests.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Conceived and designed the experiments: ABP, SAB

Performed the experiments: SV, AS, ABP, SAB

Analysed the data: SV, SAB

Contributed reagents/materials/analysis tools: ABP, SAB

All the authors reviewed the manuscript.

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Add details of the ISSF vaccination grant, Saudamini's Darwin Trust funding, ABPs Chancellors Fellowship, Amy Sweeny's Darwin Trust funding, SAB RS and BMGF. - what else?

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TABLES

Table 1: Posterior predictions of model parameters for random intercept Gaussian model $E \sim \text{Normal}(\alpha[ID] + H + D + V + V : H, \sigma)$.

Parameter	Mean	Std	5%	50%	95%
Intercept	1.02	0.85	-0.39	1.032	2.43
Habitat	-0.519	0.806	-1.863	-0.513	0.795
Diet	-0.253	0.072	-0.373	-0.253	-0.137
A	0.0	0.871	-3.307	-1.892	-0.438
D	2.062	0.856	-1.228	0.175	1.598
AD	1.256	0.875	-2.061	-0.651	0.84
DA	3.652	0.87	0.343	1.751	3.215
DD	2.996	0.865	-0.304	1.091	2.534
A:H	0.0	0.818	-0.864	0.47	1.831
D:H	-0.594	0.811	-1.434	-0.125	1.223
AD:H	-0.371	0.823	-1.244	0.103	1.472
DA:H	-1.348	0.818	-2.228	-0.874	0.496
DD:H	-0.527	0.818	-1.389	-0.061	1.31

Environmental drivers of low vaccine responsiveness in a lab-to-wild rodent model

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29th August 2024

SUPPLEMENTARY INFORMATION

Supp methods

Insert additional details about the lab mouse colony details of the diet make up of Trans-Breed and RM1

Supplementary Data: Multilevel Models

Supplementary Data: SCM construction

Supplementary Data: SCM specification

Supplementary Data: Wood mouse data

Supplementary Figures

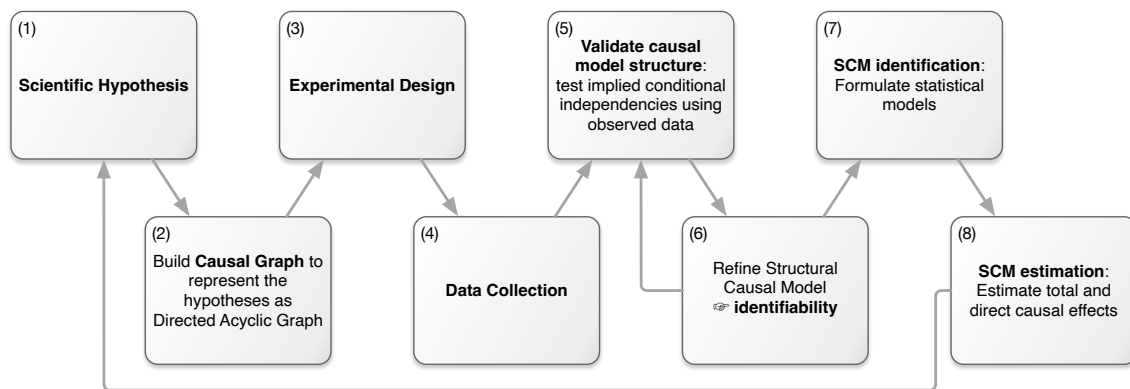


Fig. S1: Flow diagram of the SCM. The Structural Causal Model (SCM) process explicitly represents scientific hypotheses (1) as a directed acyclic graph (DAG). This DAG is mathematically encoded as a set of nested equations that describe the flow of causation between variables, and helps inform lab and field experimental design (3) and data collection (4). After processing, the data are used to test the validity of the causal assumptions underlying the SCM, e.g. by testing the conditional independencies implied by the DAG (5). If the assumptions are not supported, refinements of the SCM (6) are necessary. When all conditions are met, the SCM is identifiable and statistical models can be formulated to adjust for confounding (7). Parameters from these models can then be used as estimates of direct and indirect causal effects (8).

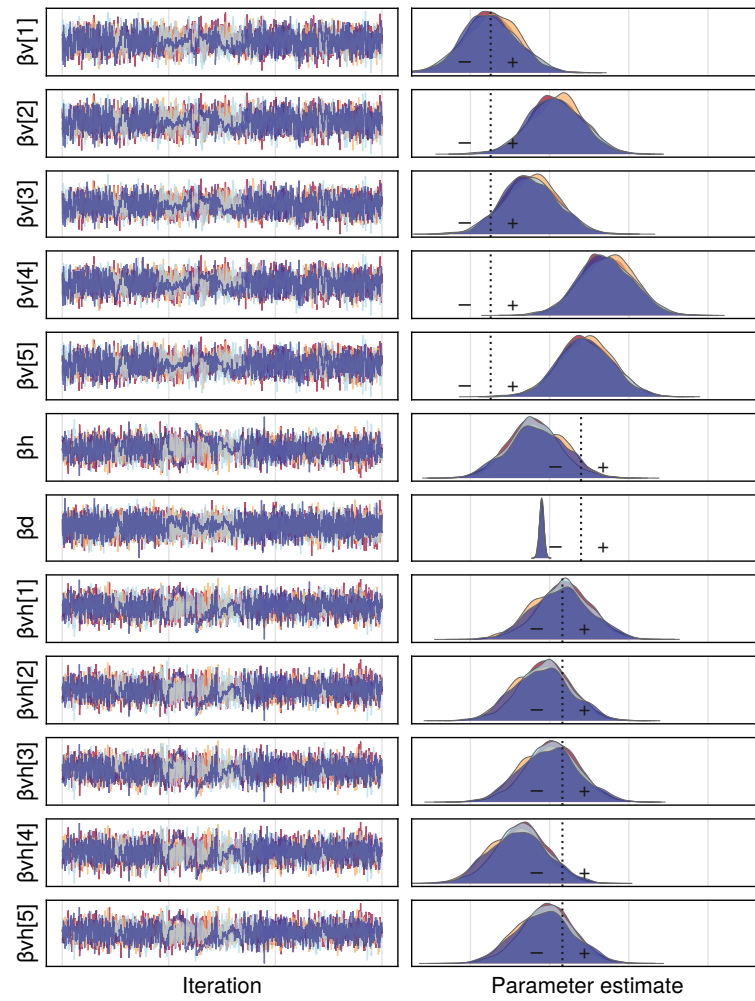


Fig. S2: MCMC chains and posterior distributions of coefficients for Diet, Habitat, Time post immunisation, and vaccine formulations A, AD, D, DA, and DD.